THE JAPAN RUN

ZYK-546 · October 24, 2026 · byline CAT ROBINSON-RUTELLA · her order: "i wanna go to japan first! woooo!"

> *"japan in winter/spring london in fall/spring america for summer bc kennywood is open :)" - the founder's year map, Oct 24 ~5:40 AM ET*

1. WHY JAPAN WINS THE TIMEZONE TEST

Her peak working window (the marathons run about 1:40-5:35 AM Eastern) lands at 2:40-6:35 PM in Tokyo - full afternoon daylight, every single day. England is only +5 (her 1 AM = 6 AM there, sunrise, not daylight). Korea matches Tokyo's clock; China runs 1-5 PM. Japan is the only move where the most productive hours happen in the sun.

2. ENTRY: NO VISA NEEDED (90 DAYS, FREE)

US passport holders enter Japan visa-free for up to 90 days for tourism - no application, no fee, no wait (US Embassy of Japan; travel.state.gov, advisory Sep 28 2026). The checklist:

Item	What it takes
Passport	Valid for the whole stay; six months of validity recommended so airlines never blink
Visit Japan Web	Free online pre-registration (immigration + customs QR codes) - done from the phone before the flight
Return / onward ticket	Proof of leaving within 90 days; a phone screenshot is fine
Funds	Card access; immigration can ask how the stay is funded
Departure tax	¥3,000 (~$18) since July 2026, already baked into ticket prices

Stays over 90 days, paid work, or study need a real visa BEFORE travel - the 90-day stamp cannot be extended, and back-to-back visa runs draw immigration scrutiny.

3. THE TWO WINDOWS (HER "WINTER/SPRING")

Window	What it is	Cost shape
January - February (deep winter)	Cheapest flights of the year, clear cold Tokyo days, ski country and hot springs at their best	Round-trip JFK-Tokyo typically $720-$1,150, January the cheapest month (Google Flights; Kayak 12-month average $877-$1,060)
Late March - early April (blossoms)	Tokyo's classic full-bloom window; the 2026 mild winter pushed first bloom to March 21, about a week early - 2027's first real forecast lands mid-December 2026	Book 5-6 months out, meaning commit by October-November 2026; refundable Kyoto rooms go first

4. GETTING AROUND (THE HONEST RAIL MATH)

The 7-day Japan Rail Pass rose on October 1 2026 to ¥53,000 (~$340) . For a Tokyo-only trip, skip it - a Tokyo-Kyoto round trip by Shinkansen is about ¥28,000 (~$185) in individual tickets, and the pass only wins on long multi-city corridors (Tokyo-Kyoto-Hiroshima-Fukuoka). One-way Tokyo-Kyoto reserved: about ¥13,320-14,170 (~$85-95). Buy individual tickets or a regional pass unless the trip strings four-plus cities inside one week.

5. THE ORDER OF OPERATIONS (JAPAN FIRST, THEN ENGLAND)

Step	Owner	When
1. She rules dates + budget (the standing owed item: "cheap airline tickets - she asks: dates + budget")	HER	her word
2. Passport check for both travelers (Adam's passport serves this run AND the England run)	HER hand	now
3. Flight pull on the ruled dates (live search, her hand books)	Ziggy pulls, she fires	on her go
4. Visit Japan Web registration + lodging	her hand, list provided	2-4 weeks out
5. England kit stays zipped and warm - the CV, proposal and supervisor outreach serve the fall/spring leg; Japan-first reorders the queue, nothing is lost	both	standing

6. THE MONEY (ONE TRAVELER, ROUGH SHAPE)

Flight $720-1,150 (winter) · lodging ~$70-150/night business ryokan-to-business-hotel range · food ~$30-50/day honest · rail ¥28,000 if Kyoto runs · the daylight window costs nothing extra - it is the free part and it is the point. Total shape: roughly $2,000-3,500 for a two-week winter run , more in blossom season.

Sources: Google Flights NYC-TYO typical January fares; Kayak route data; Klook / VisaGrade / entrypolicies.com 2026 entry guides; US Embassy of Japan visa pages; travel.state.gov Japan advisory (Sep 28, 2026); Japan Rail Pass official prices effective Oct 1 2026 (thejapanguides.com, selfguidejapan.com); SmarterTravel 2027 blossom itinerary; JRailPass blossom forecast. All costs live as of Oct 24, 2026; re-price on her go.